



er advantage is that it is very light on the system.

Verdict: *NTI Professional detects all major CD Writers and is easy to use, but it doesn't offer any outstanding features.*

Easy CD Creator 5 Platinum: This is a big software as far as install size is concerned—but it's worth it, given the extensive feature list. The software sports one of the neatest interfaces, making it easy to access different features. Access to the submenu is through the main menu, and it's very difficult to make mistakes. The software comes bundled with Direct CD, which allows you to drag-and-drop files from Windows Explorer. To increase audio and video quality, Easy CD has built-in filtering software.

Creating an audio or video CD takes just one click. Copying a CD using the CD Copier option is an easy task. Those who regularly take backups on CDs will be pleased with Take Two backup tool, which takes backups and even looks for updates on your drive. Like other CD burning software, Easy CD Creator has an online Web Check Tool and a CD label creator.

Verdict: *This is one of the best designed and most feature-rich CD burning software available.*

Prassi PrimoCD Plus: This one has a relatively simple interface. The software takes very little time to install—it has an install size of just 2.23 MB and no memory-hogging tray icons. Instead, it has very small buttons that take just a few attempts to get used to.

Burning a data/audio/video CD is very easy as there are buttons for them on the main interface. This speeds up the process by eliminating scrolling time. A box at the bottom displays appropriate messages to guide the user.

Is my CD-Writer too Fast for my PC?

CD-Writer speeds now touch 52X but is your system capable of sustaining those data transfer rates? Does buying a fast CD-Writer make sense when you have a slow performing system? Well, don't be fooled into upgrading just because you bought a fast CD-Writer. For your 'fast' CD-Writer to give you optimal performance, it is sufficient to have a PC with a 500 MHz processor with 128 MB RAM (256 MB recommended). Though the data transfer rate to the writer is fast, it is still much lower than the data throughput a hard drive can achieve. Hence, any 5,400-rpm hard drive should suffice.

Clicking on the graphical representation of the media in the recorder brings up Disk Explorer and the Properties menu, displaying information regarding the media. It also has a step-by-step help file in HTML format.

There's a list of supported formats and a comprehensive error message list. The software has good support on the Net and is a good choice for those looking for a stable and hassle-free CD writing software.

Verdict: *This is a well-developed CD burning software but the interface could do with a facelift.*

Taking Care of Your Optical Drive

- Never use poor quality detergents and sprays for cleaning. Clean the drives using a soft, dry fabric.
- Keep the tray clean. Use a duster for thorough cleaning.
- Use a UPS (Uninterrupted Power Supply) for your computer and the Writer. This will protect your system from any surge or dip in power.
- Do not push the tray to close it; always use the eject button instead.
- Never try to force the tray out, if it doesn't eject automatically. Use the pin provided with the drive to manually remove the tray.
- Use a good quality lens cleaner to keep the lens clean, as this is one of the most important parts of the drive.